REBOOTING INDIA'S SILICON VALLEY

KRISHNA BYRE GOWDA, MINISTER FOR GREATER BENGALURU DEVELOPMENT, IS A MAN ON A MISSION, TO SOLVE A PROBLEM CALLED BENGALURU—BIT BY UNRULY BIT. A MASTER PLAN IS ALSO BREWING. CAN THE TWO REINVENT THE IT CITY FOR THE AGE OF AI?

By Ajay Sukumaran



If **the city looms like a giant mathematical riddle, against its skyline are getting silhouetted shapes** yearning towards resolution. The force of human will, the persuasive power of ideas, all trying to bring order and coherence to the urban jungle. Picture a man, lean and hungry for action, tilting his lance against immovable objects. Krishna Byre Gowda, minister for Greater Bengaluru development, is a politician by vocation but a technocrat by instinct. At home with arcane points of policy and law, but also a natural out there in the field. He's as likely to be found making a slide-backed presentation on a TED video as he can be found on the side of a Bengaluru street, pointing to a clogged drain or fussing over the presence of garbage and the absence of municipal workers. He likes to keep things clean: plans, actions and, by common reputation, matters of personal probity. If a road gets white-topped according to an older plan, even if it's just about to be dug for a new flyover, it would be par for the course in an Indian city. One more contract, some more money going around. But not for Byre Gowda: the other day, he screamed at officials for the sheer waste of public money and got cracking on a single digital platform for monitoring civic works.

It's tempting to paint this as the picture of one man in kinetic war against the sloth, anarchy and inbred stasis of a city that refuses to submit to planning. But the story of Bengaluru spins out much further from here, via a maze of dotted lines that don't entirely interconnect right now. There's a Master Plan in the making for 2037. It's less a municipal vision, more an economic charter for how the IT hub of the 1990s can grow up to become the megalopolis of the age of AI. The primary force it applies on present-day reality is centrifugal—radiating outward, dispersing, untying the Gordian knot so wide as to reconstitute itself at a much larger scale. The year 2037 marks the 500th anniversary of the founding of Bengaluru by Kempe Gowda. As if in deference, the Master Plan plots on paper a future metropolitan region that's a dozen times—at 8,000 sq. km, it will dwarf

> **"This is the first time after 2006 that some tendering for garbage collection has reached a final stage. I'm confident we can make tangible improvement"**
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> **KRISHNA BYRE GOWDA**
> *Minister for Greater Bengaluru Development, Karnataka*